

**THE PICTURE
OF
DORIAN GRAY**

Oscar Wilde

Edited by James Gifford

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INTRODUCTION

IN 1890, Oscar Wilde published the first version of *The Picture of Dorian Gray* in *Lippincott's Monthly Magazine*. After vociferous public responses to the novel's "one element... which will taint every young mind that comes in contact with it" (Mason 69), Wilde completed his revisions, expanding the novel by half again and adding his now famous "Preface" for what, in 1891, became the standard version of the novel. This situation leaves readers with two distinct and very different versions of this literary masterpiece, one from 1890 and another from 1891 that followed on the harsh public response. This edition uses the British edition of the often overlooked 1890 printing prior to Wilde's (and his copy editor Coulson Kernahan's) expansions and expurgations of the text, expansions that include the "Preface" he added to explain the artwork's relationship to the morality of the artist and audience.

How do we read the "Preface" that stands between the two volumes, translating their aesthetic visions as well as deflecting public criticisms? Do we read it as an ironic way of avoiding the growing criticism of Wilde's then presumed homosexuality, or do we accept it as a sincere aesthetic manifesto? Is it, as Gillespie conceives Wilde's process, an instance of "learn[ing] the value or the wisdom of adhering to certain limits within society's strictures" (*Oscar* 55)? In either case, the postscript "Preface" influences our view of the novel as a whole. However, we still need to ask *which* novel we are reading: the 1890 original (in either its British or American editions) or the far more common and readily available 1891 revision that significantly responded to social criticisms? For students and popular readers, the 1891 text is far more common and the only practically available edition. Although Michael Gillespie's excellent classroom edition of *The Picture of Dorian Gray* through Norton includes both versions of the text, its critical apparatus clearly distinguishes the

1890 edition as predecessor rather than a viable work for study in its own right. Joseph Bristow's editorship of *The Complete Works of Oscar Wilde* contains the most detailed work on the 1890 and 1891 versions of the novel, but it is impractical for classroom use, and the subsequent student edition by Oxford contains only the 1891 text. In practice, the 1891 recreation of Wilde's novel has become the editorial copy-text for all editions for student use. However, there are consequences to these choices. Wilde's aesthetic declarations shift rapidly between the two published versions of *The Picture of Dorian Gray*, and his comments in other contemporary works again point to different interpretive ventures. In nearly all instances, the "Preface" published between the two primary editions acts as arbiter, either directing attention to the work's aesthetics or deflecting attention from its expression of the author's aims and social goals.

The aesthetic opinions as well as the descriptions of the relationship between art and artist here, in the 1890 edition, are more akin to those found in Wilde's story "The Portrait of Mr. W.H." and other works of the same period. These aesthetic views often defy those articulated in the later "Preface" to the revised novel. The reader is told (after the initial poor critical response to the morality of the 1890 novel) that "The artist is the creator of beautiful things" and "To reveal art and conceal the artist is art's aim" (159). In more plain terms, the art product is a consumable object in an economy, but it reveals nothing of the artist whose sole function is to create beautiful things that consumers wish to purchase and enjoy. The first implication recalls Wilde's complaint in the novel that "we know the price of everything and the value of nothing" (31). The second implication is that the artist is not himself among these "beautiful things" that others may choose to purchase for an agreed-upon price. Not only, in anticipation of T.S. Eliot, is the artist *not* expressed in some personal way in the final artistic product, she or he must be *more* than simply absent. She must be actively concealed from the consumer of the artwork. This situation is akin to classical alienation from labour, and the fact that Wilde's own works frequently contradict this exclusion of the artist hardly merits defense – it is overt. Wilde demonstrably regarded the artist as a social critic

and wrote works that reveal himself as well as his aesthetics. This was generally for the purpose of social transformation in line with his antiauthoritarian and Irish Nationalist politics. The artwork is certainly more than simply a “beautiful thing” and the artist more than simply a creator of such objects.

Moreover, while Wilde’s later “Preface” may argue against the revelation of the artist in his art, the exclusion of the artist from the artistic product runs contrary to the greatest artwork in the novel: Basil Hallward’s picture of Dorian Gray itself. The picture is great insofar as it shows both Basil’s and Dorian’s hidden “souls,” a topic Elizabeth Lorang demonstrates is particularly important to the 1890 *Lippincott’s* state of the text (22). Basil’s greatest fear is that his finest artistic creation of a “beautiful thing” will reveal too much of himself, though this revelation is very likely the reason for its greatness. Basil’s homoerotic love for Dorian is revealed in his work, and his hidden soul “speaks.” In this scenario, the artist is revealed in precisely the same image that the audience, in this case Dorian himself, refuses to see. He cannot notice Basil’s love reflected in the painting. Dorian, likewise, is revealed in the artwork’s transformation to show his social transgressions, and for this reason he must closet it, literally, so that his social face will be gray, as in his namesake, despite the colours shown by the painting and embodied in the multi-coloured flowers that appear throughout the novel.

This is also very much akin to Wilde’s “The Portrait of Mr. W.H.,” in which another portrait of a beautiful young man is created in order to support a new interpretation of Shakespeare’s Sonnets. However, this is only possible so long as the portrait can reveal the soul of its instigator (though not its artist) while concealing its secret. For both scenarios, the audience is unable or refuses to understand what the image communicates apart from its overt content, and the result in both instances is death. In the reading strategies instigated in this contemporary story to *The Picture of Dorian Gray*, Wilde argues that great works of art (such as Shakespeare’s Sonnets) not only fail to privilege art over the artist but actively express the artist’s hidden life and passions rather than conceal them, just as Basil’s portrait reveals his secret love and Dorian’s secret soul. The portrait of Mr.

W.H. communicates the same message, and like Basil's love for Dorian, it communicates a form of love that is also censored in tandem with the interpretive activities it would prompt. Likewise, even while Wilde later contends "There is no such thing as a moral or an immoral book," he gives Dorian a beautiful "yellow book" (again specific in colour juxtaposed to Dorian's lack of colour as Mr. "Gray"), and this book is certainly corrupting, leading the reader to Huysmans' novel *À Rebours*. In all three regards, the novel itself and its contemporaries in Wilde's *oeuvre* lead the reader away from the overt declarations of the later "Preface" that tries to distance the artist from the artwork and hence to spare the artist from public critique for immorality. In all cases, the overt contents of the "beautiful thing" are demonstrably insufficient.

A form of reading intent on insinuation, obfuscation, and allusion is certainly privileged in all of Wilde's narratives of reading or interpreting, even while his "Preface" declares such approaches a "peril" to the reader (160). This suggests the "Preface" must itself be read using similar strategies, and this places the standard 1891 text of *The Picture of Dorian Gray* and its "Preface" in a position of dependence in relation to its predecessor from 1890. Moreover, the irony that we now see in this "Preface" is crucial when it declares "All art is perfectly useless." Though often taken as a declaration of the Art for Art's Sake movement, this position avoids Wilde's self-identification as an anarchist (Goodway 62-9, Woodcock 379-82) and his satire of the English aristocracy in his plays – the utility of the artwork is never in question, since it is clearly designed for a socially satiric function. Rather, the "perfectly useless" art reflects the autonomy of the artist and the artwork such that its authority for existence stands independent of the social and state apparatus of authoritarian power, even when art serves to resist such power. Art does not require a "use value" in order to be art, or as Carolyn Lesjak argues, "the notion of pleasure in [Wilde's] texts dovetails with notions of use versus exchange value, commodification and commodity logic, the utopian and the everyday" (180). To hierarchical power structures, the artwork and the artist are "perfectly useless." Legitimate art, insofar as it is individualist, is

“useless” to authoritarian exercises of power, though it can certainly express the artist and exert influence over the audience, albeit an influence that does not impinge on that audience’s personal autonomy. Refusing utility *is* the politics of this art.

The implication, then, is that Wilde’s later “Preface” and revisions to the body of the novel reflect a different spirit of reading as well as his personal desire to avoid the spirited responses of his critics. The “Preface” is certainly more than a scurrilous distraction from the revealing 1890 edition, yet it is too often taken as an injunction to grant preference or authority to the later edition that avoids social complications and difficulties. The “Preface,” then, becomes dangerous if it leads readers to refrain from acknowledging what was communicated in the less obfuscated primary text of 1890. For this reason, the “Preface” appears here in the Appendix rather than preceding the body of the novel. It is ancillary rather than primary in this edition.

There is another issue at stake in selecting a copy text. While the later 1891 edition is significantly enlarged, it is also significantly cut. The “Preface” served its role in protecting Wilde’s safety for a time. By superficially declaring that the novel reflected nothing of himself, Wilde temporarily avoided the potential for charges of homosexuality, which would have been (and later were) disastrous for his writing career and personal liberty. Homosexuality was criminal and punishable by imprisonment with hard labour, and it had only been repealed as a crime punishable by execution in Britain in 1861. In many ways, what had spoken perhaps too earnestly in *Lippincott’s* in 1890 did not dare to speak again in 1891, and this censorship, even if superficial, protected the author. In a letter to Sir Arthur Conan Doyle, who conceived his second Sherlock Holmes work *The Sign of Four* during the same dinner as Wilde offered *Dorian Gray* in August 1889, Wilde reveals some of his surprise at the public reaction:

The newspapers seem to be to be written by the prurient for the Philistine. I cannot understand how they can treat *Dorian Gray* as immoral. My difficulty was to keep the inherent moral subordinate to the artistic and dramatic effect, and it

still seems to me that the moral is too obvious. (Doyle 95)

Wilde was most likely responding to a particularly harsh review in *The Chronicle* that contends

There is not a single good and holy impulse of human nature, scarcely a fine feeling or instinct that civilisation, art, and religion have developed throughout the ages as part of the barrier between Humanity and Animalism that is not held up to ridicule and contempt in “Dorian Gray,” if, indeed, such strong words can be fitly applied to the actual effect of Mr Wilde’s airy levity and fluent impudence. His desperate attempt to vamp up a “moral” for the book at the end is, artistically speaking, coarse and crude because the whole incident of Dorian Gray’s death is, as they say on the stage, “out of the picture.” (Mason 67)

In addition to its invisibility, the “moral” of Dorian’s punishment as well as Basil’s is further subordinated by virtue of being enacted by the plot rather than by the direct statement of a moralizing narrator. Wilde’s letter to Doyle also implicitly contrasts Wilde’s ‘immorality’ to Doyle’s first introduction of Holme’s cocaine addiction, which ritualized drug use and left the transgressor unpunished in the plot, though it receives the condemnation of Dr. Watson. Lorang has insightfully noted that this absent moral also contrasts inside the 1890 British edition of *Lippincott’s* against the final installment of Coulson Kernahan’s *A Diary of a Dead Man* (30). Nonetheless, Doyle’s work aroused far less condemnation than Wilde’s, and Kernahan’s was praised. The difference makes visible Victorian interests and anxieties (Hodgson 41-45).

Wilde’s aim to “keep the moral subordinate” is telling, and Basil’s punishment in the plot arouses only our sympathy rather than a homophobic moral rectitude. However, the moral’s “too obvious” presence shaped his return to the novel during revisions after the *Lippincott’s* publication, and the obvious was made overt. Wilde stated clearly that he would not cut a single line from the novel for the

1891 revision. In a typical Wildean manner, he lived up to this statement – rather than a single line, he instead cut dozens of significant passages while expanding others in ways that censored or redirected the novel’s social critique in order to draw forward the “too obvious” moral he would otherwise have preferred to “subordinate to the artistic and dramatic effect.”

The novel also shows Dorian learning how to read and interpret, just as many first-time readers of the novel often do in a first year university course when developing skills of analysis and active reading by engaging with the novel. A didacticism of reading and interpreting is readily apparent in the novel as a whole. As the self-censorship and concealment of the artist seems to suggest, the reader has materials hidden from view just as Dorian hides his sins in the course of the narrative or Basil his love in his artwork. As with Wilde’s later description of the “love that dare not speak its name” (a phrase taken from his lover, Lord Alfred Douglas), a shift in emphasis from the word “dare” to “speak” alters potential critical interventions. This censored form of love is a major part of what was concealed ever more fully by the continued development of the novel. In 1890, *The Picture of Dorian Gray* dared, as did “The Portrait of Mr. W.H.” It dared to communicate that which it could not *speak* directly, as the critical response proves. There was little confusion over the meaning the 1890 novel dared to present, nor was there great doubt over the form of love it explored. What it did not dare was to expressly “speak” the same things it had clearly succeeded in communicating. Instead, the speaking voice, the voice of the narrator, displaces ambiguity at precisely the moment when Dorian learns to read what has been hidden from him throughout the novel: his own self-censored wishes, his self-knowledge. At each moment Dorian arrives at self-exploration or an authentic experience outside of authoritarian social or moral restrictions, the novel moves into censorship and Dorian’s inability to recognize himself. Self-recognition eludes him. He may transgress social norms, but he does so unselfconsciously, whereas Basil need not make such transgressions because he is already self-aware and able to express and communicate without “speaking” that which society cannot

permit. Following after Dorian's first major ethical transgression (his cruel rejection of Sybil), Dorian shuns self-knowledge and instead pursues a cruel life of self-delusion in which he is unable to recognize himself and demonstrably misreads the picture's visual presentations of the moral state of his soul. Wilde does not condemn nor condone any particular behaviour on the part of Dorian. The novel instead points to the way that social stigmas and conditions dominate his transgressions just as much as they dominate his conformities – in no instance does Dorian develop as an individual who, from that position of autonomy, generates *mores* as an independent yet social being. The extrinsic imposition of social *mores* shapes Dorian's self-censorship and exploration of immorality. At no point does he build from his own experiences to a new form of social existence predicated on the autonomous individual.

While it is tempting to anachronistically read such a moment through psychoanalytic notions of repression, Wilde does not require this. The reader need not move beyond contemporary late nineteenth century questions about the stability of the self and self-knowledge. In 1890, when Dorian sees the hypocritical visage adopted by his hideous image in the painting, following after his decision to reclaim "his rose-white boyhood" (17, 140), the reader is left with a question from the narrator: "Hypocrisy? Had there been nothing more in his renunciation [of his life of sin] than that? There had been something more. At least he thought so. But who could tell?" (141-2). This "something more" that cannot be seen by another person ("who could tell?"), or that cannot be spoken, is instead given voice in Wilde's 1891 revision: "No. There had been nothing more. Through vanity he had spared her. In hypocrisy he had worn the mask of goodness. For curiosity's sake he had tried the denial of self. He recognized that now." The contrast between the editions is highly striking: "There had been something more" (142) in 1890 is denied in 1891 after public recriminations for immorality were made against Wilde in response to the novel's daring communication of the love that dare not speak openly. Wilde's addition to the passage in 1891 negates the previously open text: "No. There had been nothing more." The reader is guided away

from a subtle examination of this “something more” and away from perilously reading beneath the surface of the text that denies it. The reader does not need to engage in an anachronistic Freudian notion of repression in order to recognize the suppression apparent in the original and revised forms of the text. It is equally uncomplicated to see that Wilde’s play with self-censorship and hidden desires in his characters reflects what he experienced as a real social situation within which he lived and in which his novel would be published.

More plainly, in 1890, Dorian is unable to comprehend himself and shrinks from the complexities of genuine self-examination while the reader is concomitantly placed in a position of complex interpretive responsibility. The reader must adopt Dorian’s position and the demands of self-knowledge by grappling with the text’s refusal to grant closure – the reader is an autonomous individual influenced by the art but ultimately making his or her own decisions with regard to it. We all must decide for ourselves the nature of the “something more” in Dorian’s hypocrisy. In 1891, under growing social pressure, the novel forecloses on this interpretive activity and upholds a socially normative sanction against Dorian by declaring that his reformation is false and hence his demise is apt punishment for social transgression. Social values are reinscribed over the autonomy of the individual – by punishing Dorian, our vicarious pleasure in his sins is permitted while denied. The act of resistance implicit in 1890 becomes a form of consolation or substitution that upholds the authoritarian social norm in 1891.

Furthermore, rather than speaking what this “something more” might be, something that could illuminate Dorian’s interior life or that might explore the nature of the homosocial relations in the novel, the narrator dares not speak anything that reveals the artist. Just as Basil Hallward cannot speak the adoration his painting dares to express, the narrator after this 1890 edition must censor the range of interpretive opportunities. Unlike Wilde’s essay “The Decay of Lying” or his subsequent puns on the vital importance of being earnest in his last play, Dorian does not learn to lie in a manner that communicates truthfully nor that allows self-exploration under the protection of social duplicity. Nor does he achieve the anarchist

autonomy longed for in “The Soul of Man Under Socialism,” which argues for an antiauthoritarian privileging of the individual as the basis for developing an ethical engagement with the social world via personal experience and self-knowledge. “The Soul of Man Under Socialism” adopts phrases from the anarchist writers Peter Kropotkin and Pierre-Joseph Proudhon, and Kropotkin describes the work to Wilde’s close friend Robert Ross as “that article that O. Wilde wrote on Anarchism” (113). George Woodcock, in his classic study *Anarchism*, describes Wilde’s 1891 work as “The most ambitious contribution to literary anarchism during the 1890s” (379). It also argues for an equitable and free society built from the autonomy of the individual who discovers ethics through self-exploration rather than through extrinsic imposition. Instead, for Dorian at the conclusion of the novel, the socially normative punishment for transgression must fall on the transgressor, matching Wilde’s own definition of Fiction in his later play “The Importance of Being Earnest.” As Miss Prism explains to Cecily, in a moment that must surely reflect back on Wilde’s own novel, “The good ended happily, and the bad unhappily. That is what Fiction means” (376). In other words, social propriety demands the performance of normative roles, even while individual aims are pursued, although the net effect in such a situation, even when one achieves one’s desires, is the diminishment of the personal as ancillary and the promotion of the social as primary.

A further problem, however, lies in Wilde’s own Symbolist language in the final scene in *The Picture of Dorian Gray*. Dorian wishes to reclaim “his rose-white boyhood” without ‘speaking’ the “rose-red youth” that accompanied it (141), the two phrases having occurred in immediate juxtaposition at the outset of the novel (18). Passion and purity – intensity and social conformity. To recognize the ‘red’ being read in this colour-laden novel would be to repeat “the rage of Caliban seeing his own face in a glass,” as Wilde describes in his later “Preface” (159). Like Caliban’s rage, Dorian cannot face what he does not dare to speak, and the result is his demise during the act of denial or self-censorship. Quite literally, Dorian attempts to murder that which he cannot accept within himself – his “rose-red youth” –

and in doing so, he murders himself. The socially-desired “rose-white youth” is only one element of Dorian as an individual, and the social rejection of this red and white duality leads Dorian to stagnation, immorality, and ultimately to self-destruction.

Like Basil’s fear that in his painting of Dorian “I have shown... the secret of my own soul” (5), Wilde appears to have feared revealing that which he dared not speak in this first version of his own picture of Dorian Gray: his own homosexuality in repressive Victorian society. Yet, he did dare to communicate it. The result is a knife taken to the canvas of the picture just as a knife (and pen) were taken to this first 1890 publication during its revision in 1891 in order to tame its daring communications. While the violence of the image of an authorial knife may be overly strong, the implication is exact: Wilde cut his initial vision in order to assuage public opinion, and in doing so he distracted the reader’s attention and interpretive autonomy from the problems of sexuality, self-knowledge, and anarchism that shaped the initial form of the novel.

By making students and readers aware of this 1890 edition as not only an ancillary text but as a primary text in its own right, suitable for classroom use and general reading for which the later revisions become ancillary, the “secret” may once again be *shown* even if not *spoken* – this showing places a greater burden and autonomy on the reader, which is what every good reader deserves.

ABOUT THIS EDITION

This edition fills a gap in student-oriented publications of *The Picture of Dorian Gray*. Editions of the novel for classroom use are abundant. Gillespie’s work for Norton, Norman Page’s for Broadview, and Bristow’s for Oxford stand out as the most reliable and widely available. However, all classroom editions privilege the 1891 edition of the text. This new digital edition makes the 1890 instantiation of the novel available for classroom use, for which its shorter length and clearer thematic aims make it highly useful. As an entirely electronic edition available in several states, this edition encourages a

blended learning environment that privileges the text's accessibility and portability – students have access to a standard document with uniform pagination in a Portable Document Format as well as eBook formats for a range of mobile reading devices. The annotations to this edition generally assume an undergraduate reader without significant prior experience with Victorian literature. Bristow's 2005 critical edition is the work of record for advanced scholars.

TEXTUAL NOTES

In instances when Wilde italicized foreign words and then failed to italicize on subsequent appearances, I have italicized throughout. Ligatures have been modernized throughout. The University of Victoria's McPherson Library provided the copy-text of the 1890 British *Lippincott's Monthly Magazine* edition of the novel. A digital replica of the original is available with this edition.

THE PICTURE

OF

DORIAN GRAY

CHAPTER I

THE studio was filled with the rich odor of roses, and when the light summer wind stirred amidst the trees of the garden there came through the open door the heavy scent of the lilac, or the more delicate perfume of the pink-flowering thorn.

From the corner of the divan of Persian saddle-bags on which he was lying, smoking, as usual, innumerable cigarettes, Lord Henry Wotton could just catch the gleam of the honey-sweet and honey-colored blossoms of the laburnum, whose tremulous branches seemed hardly able to bear the burden of a beauty so flame-like as theirs¹; and now and then the fantastic shadows of birds in flight flitted across the long tussore-silk curtains that were stretched in front of the huge window, producing a kind of momentary Japanese effect, and making him think of those pallid jade-faced painters who, in an art that is necessarily immobile, seek to convey the sense of swiftness and motion. The sullen murmur of the bees shouldering their way through the long unmown grass, or circling with monotonous insistence round the black-crocketed spires of the early June hollyhocks, seemed to make the stillness more oppressive, and the dim roar of London was like the bourdon note of a distant organ.

In the centre of the room, clamped to an upright easel, stood the full-length portrait of a young man of extraordinary personal beauty, and in front of it, some little distance away, was sitting the artist himself, Basil Hallward, whose sudden disappearance some years ago caused, at the time, such public excitement, and gave rise to so many strange conjectures.

As he looked at the gracious and comely form he had so skilfully mirrored in his art, a smile of pleasure passed across his face, and seemed about to linger there. But he suddenly started up, and, closing his eyes, placed his fingers upon the lids, as though he sought

to imprison within his brain some curious dream from which he feared he might awake.

"It is your best work, Basil, the best thing you have ever done," said Lord Henry, languidly. "You must certainly send it next year to the Grosvenor.² The Academy is too large and too vulgar. The Grosvenor is the only place."

"I don't think I will send it anywhere," he answered, tossing his head back in that odd way that used to make his friends laugh at him at Oxford. "No: I won't send it anywhere."

Lord Henry elevated his eyebrows, and looked at him in amazement through the thin blue wreaths of smoke that curled up in such fanciful whorls from his heavy opium-tainted cigarette.³ "Not send it anywhere? My dear fellow, why? Have you any reason? What odd chaps you painters are! You do anything in the world to gain a reputation. As soon as you have one, you seem to want to throw it away. It is silly of you, for there is only one thing in the world worse than being talked about, and that is not being talked about. A portrait like this would set you far above all the young men in England, and make the old men quite jealous, if old men are ever capable of any emotion."

"I know you will laugh at me," he replied, "but I really can't exhibit it. I have put too much of myself into it."⁴

Lord Henry stretched his long legs out on the divan and shook with laughter.

"Yes, I knew you would laugh; but it is quite true, all the same."

"Too much of yourself in it! Upon my word, Basil, I didn't know you were so vain; and I really can't see any resemblance between you, with your rugged strong face and your coal-black hair, and this young Adonis,⁵ who looks as if he was made of ivory and rose-leaves. Why, my dear Basil, he is a Narcissus,⁶ and you—well, of course you have an intellectual expression, and all that. But beauty, real beauty, ends where an intellectual expression begins. Intellect is in itself an exaggeration, and destroys the harmony of any face. The moment one sits down to think, one becomes all nose, or all forehead, or something horrid. Look at the successful men in any of the learned professions. How perfectly hideous they are! Except, of course, in

the Church. But then in the Church they don't think. A bishop keeps on saying at the age of eighty what he was told to say when he was a boy of eighteen, and consequently he always looks absolutely delightful. Your mysterious young friend, whose name you have never told me,⁷ but whose picture really fascinates me, never thinks. I feel quite sure of that. He is a brainless, beautiful thing, who should be always here in winter when we have no flowers to look at, and always here in summer when we want something to chill our intelligence. Don't flatter yourself, Basil: you are not in the least like him."

"You don't understand me, Harry. Of course I am not like him. I know that perfectly well. Indeed, I should be sorry to look like him. You shrug your shoulders? I am telling you the truth. There is a fatality about all physical and intellectual distinction, the sort of fatality that seems to dog through history the faltering steps of kings. It is better not to be different from one's fellows. The ugly and the stupid have the best of it in this world. They can sit quietly and gape at the play. If they know nothing of victory, they are at least spared the knowledge of defeat. They live as we all should live, undisturbed, indifferent, and without disquiet. They neither bring ruin upon others nor ever receive it from alien hands. Your rank and wealth, Harry; my brains, such as they are,—my fame, whatever it may be worth; Dorian Gray's good looks,—we will all suffer for what the gods have given us, suffer terribly."

"Dorian Gray? is that his name?" said Lord Henry, walking across the studio towards Basil Hallward,

"Yes; that is his name. I didn't intend to tell it to you."

"But why not?"

"Oh, I can't explain. When I like people immensely I never tell their names to any one. It seems like surrendering a part of them. You know how I love secrecy. It is the only thing that can make modern life wonderful or mysterious to us. The commonest thing is delightful if one only hides it. When I leave town I never tell my people where I am going. If I did, I would lose all my pleasure. It is a silly habit, I dare say, but somehow it seems to bring a great deal of romance into one's life. I suppose you think me awfully foolish

about it?"

"Not at all," answered Lord Henry, laying his hand upon his shoulder; "not at all, my dear Basil. You seem to forget that I am married, and the one charm of marriage is that it makes a life of deception necessary for both parties. I never know where my wife is, and my wife never knows what I am doing. When we meet,—we do meet occasionally, when we dine out together, or go down to the duke's,—we tell each other the most absurd stories with the most serious faces. My wife is very good at it,—much better, in fact, than I am. She never gets confused over her dates, and I always do. But when she does find me out, she makes no row at all. I sometimes wish she would; but she merely laughs at me."

"I hate the way you talk about your married life, Harry," said Basil Hallward, shaking his hand off, and strolling towards the door that led into the garden. "I believe that you are really a very good husband, but that you are thoroughly ashamed of your own virtues. You are an extraordinary fellow. You never say a moral thing, and you never do a wrong thing. Your cynicism is simply a pose."

"Being natural is simply a pose, and the most irritating pose I know," cried Lord Henry, laughing; and the two young men went out into the garden together, and for a time they did not speak.

After a long pause Lord Henry pulled out his watch. "I am afraid I must be going, Basil," he murmured, "and before I go I insist on your answering a question I put to you some time ago."

"What is that?" asked Basil Hallward, keeping his eyes fixed on the ground.

"You know quite well."

"I do not, Harry."

"Well, I will tell you what it is."

"Please don't."

"I must. I want you to explain to me why you won't exhibit Dorian Gray's picture. I want the real reason."

"I told you the real reason."

"No, you did not. You said it was because there was too much of yourself in it. Now, that is childish."

"Harry," said Basil Hallward, looking him straight in the face,

“every portrait that is painted with feeling is a portrait of the artist, not of the sitter. The sitter is merely the accident, the occasion. It is not he who is revealed by the painter; it is rather the painter who, on the colored canvas, reveals himself. The reason I will not exhibit this picture is that I am afraid that I have shown with it the secret of my own soul.”

Lord Harry laughed. “And what is that?” he asked.

“I will tell you,” said Hallward; and an expression of perplexity came over his face.

“I am all expectation, Basil,” murmured his companion, looking at him.

“Oh, there is really very little to tell, Harry,” answered the young painter; “and I am afraid you will hardly understand it. Perhaps you will hardly believe it.”

Lord Henry smiled, and, leaning down, plucked a pink-petalled daisy from the grass, and examined it. “I am quite sure I shall understand it,” he replied, gazing intently at the little golden white-feathered disk, “and I can believe anything, provided that it is incredible.”

The wind shook some blossoms from the trees, and the heavy lilac-blooms, with their clustering stars, moved to and fro in the languid air. A grasshopper began to chirrup in the grass, and a long thin dragonfly floated by on its brown gauze wings. Lord Henry felt as if he could hear Basil Hallward’s heart beating, and he wondered what was coming.

“Well, this is incredible,” repeated Hallward, rather bitterly,—“incredible to me at times. I don’t know what it means. The story is simply this. Two months ago I went to a crush⁹ at Lady Brandon’s. You know we poor painters have to show ourselves in society from time to time, just to remind the public that we are not savages. With an evening coat and a white tie, as you told me once, anybody, even a stock-broker, can gain a reputation for being civilized. Well, after I had been in the room about ten minutes, talking to huge overdressed dowagers and tedious Academicians, I suddenly became conscious that some one was looking at me. I turned half-way round, and saw Dorian Gray for the first time. When our eyes met, I felt that I was

growing pale. A curious instinct of terror came over me. I knew that I had come face to face with some one whose mere personality was so fascinating that, if I allowed it to do so, it would absorb my whole nature, my whole soul, my very art itself. I did not want any external influence in my life. You know yourself, Harry, how independent I am by nature. My father destined me for the army. I insisted on going to Oxford. Then he made me enter my name at the Middle Temple. Before I had eaten half a dozen dinners I gave up the Bar, and announced my intention of becoming a painter. I have always been my own master; had at least always been so, till I met Dorian Gray. Then—— But I don't know how to explain it to you. Something seemed to tell me that I was on the verge of a terrible crisis in my life. I had a strange feeling that Fate had in store for me exquisite joys and exquisite sorrows.¹⁰ I knew that if I spoke to Dorian I would become absolutely devoted to him, and that I ought not to speak to him. I grew afraid, and turned to quit the room. It was not conscience that made me do so: it was cowardice. I take no credit to myself for trying to escape.”

“Conscience and cowardice are really the same things, Basil. Conscience is the trade-name of the firm. That is all.”

“I don't believe that, Harry. However, whatever was my motive,—and it may have been pride, for I used to be very proud,—I certainly struggled to the door. There, of course, I stumbled against Lady Brandon. ‘You are not going to run away so soon, Mr. Hallward?’ she screamed out. You know her shrill horrid voice?”

“Yes; she is a peacock in everything but beauty,” said Lord Henry, pulling the daisy to bits with his long, nervous fingers.

“I could not get rid of her. She brought me up to Royalties, and people with Stars and Garters,¹¹ and elderly ladies with gigantic tiaras and hooked noses. She spoke of me as her dearest friend. I had only met her once before, but she took it into her head to lionize me. I believe some picture of mine had made a great success at the time, at least had been chattered about in the penny newspapers, which is the nineteenth-century standard of immortality. Suddenly I found myself face to face with the young man whose personality had so strangely stirred me. We were quite close, almost touching. Our eyes met

again. It was mad of me, but I asked Lady Brandon to introduce me to him. Perhaps it was not so mad, after all. It was simply inevitable. We would have spoken to each other without any introduction. I am sure of that. Dorian told me so afterwards. He, too, felt that we were destined to know each other.”

“And how did Lady Brandon describe this wonderful young man? I know she goes in for giving a rapid *précis* of all her guests. I remember her bringing me up to a most truculent and red-faced old gentleman covered all over with orders and ribbons, and hissing into my ear, in a tragic whisper which must have been perfectly audible to everybody in the room, something like ‘Sir Humpty Dumpty—you know—Afghan-frontier—Russian intrigues: very successful man—wife killed by an elephant—quite inconsolable—wants to marry a beautiful American widow—everybody does nowadays—hates Mr. Gladstone—but very much interested in beetles: ask him what he thinks of Schouvaloff.’ I simply fled. I like to find out people for myself. But poor Lady Brandon treats her guests exactly as an auctioneer treats his goods. She either explains them entirely away, or tells one everything about them except what one wants to know. But what did she say about Mr. Dorian Gray?”

“Oh, she murmured, ‘Charming boy—poor dear mother and I quite inseparable—engaged to be married to the same man—I mean married on the same day—how very silly of me!’¹² Quite forget what he does—afraid he—doesn’t do anything—oh, yes, plays the piano—or is it the violin, dear Mr. Gray?’ We could neither of us help laughing, and we became friends at once.”

“Laughter is not a bad beginning for a friendship, and it is the best ending for one,” said Lord Henry, plucking another daisy.

Hallward buried his face in his hands. “You don’t understand what friendship is, Harry,” he murmured,— “or what enmity is, for that matter. You like every one; that is to say, you are indifferent to every one.”

“How horribly unjust of you!” cried Lord Henry, tilting his hat back, and looking up at the little clouds that were drifting across the hollowed turquoise of the summer sky, like ravelled skeins of glossy white silk. “Yes; horribly unjust of you. I make a great difference

between people. I choose my friends for their good looks, my acquaintances for their characters, and my enemies for their brains. A man can't be too careful in the choice of his enemies. I have not got one who is a fool. They are all men of some intellectual power, and consequently they all appreciate me. Is that very vain of me? I think it is rather vain."

"I should think it was, Harry. But according to your category I must be merely an acquaintance."

"My dear old Basil, you are much more than an acquaintance."

"And much less than a friend. A sort of brother, I suppose?"

"Oh, brothers! I don't care for brothers. My elder brother won't die, and my younger brothers seem never to do anything else."¹³

"Harry!"

"My dear fellow, I am not quite serious. But I can't help detesting my relations. I suppose it comes from the fact that we can't stand other people having the same faults as ourselves. I quite sympathize with the rage of the English democracy against what they call the vices of the upper classes. They feel that drunkenness, stupidity, and immorality should be their own special property, and that if any one of us makes an ass of himself he is poaching on their preserves. When poor Southwark got into the Divorce Court, their indignation was quite magnificent. And yet I don't suppose that ten per cent, of the lower orders live correctly."

"I don't agree with a single word that you have said, and, what is more, Harry, I don't believe you do either."

Lord Henry stroked his pointed brown beard, and tapped the toe of his patent-leather boot with a tasselled malacca cane. "How English you are, Basil! If one puts forward an idea to a real Englishman,—always a rash thing to do,—he never dreams of considering whether the idea is right or wrong. The only thing he considers of any importance is whether one believes it one's self. Now, the value of an idea has nothing whatsoever to do with the sincerity of the man who expresses it. Indeed, the probabilities are that the more insincere the man is, the more purely intellectual will the idea be, as in that case it will not be colored by either his wants, his desires, or his prejudices. However, I don't propose to discuss

politics, sociology, or metaphysics with you. I like persons better than principles. Tell me more about Dorian Gray. How often do you see him?”

“Every day. I couldn’t be happy if I didn’t see him every day. Of course sometimes it is only for a few minutes. But a few minutes with somebody one worships mean a great deal.”

“But you don’t really worship him?”

“I do.”¹⁴

“How extraordinary! I thought you would never care for anything but your painting,—your art, I should say. Art sounds better, doesn’t it?”

“He is all my art to me now. I sometimes think, Harry, that there are only two eras of any importance in the history of the world. The first is the appearance of a new medium for art, and the second is the appearance of a new personality for art also. What the invention of oil-painting was to the Venetians, the face of Antinoüs¹⁵ was to late Greek sculpture, and the face of Dorian Gray will some day be to me. It is not merely that I paint from him, draw from him, model from him. Of course I have done all that. He has stood as Paris in dainty armor, and as Adonis with huntsman’s cloak and polished boar-spear.¹⁶ Crowned with heavy lotus-blossoms, he has sat on the prow of Adrian’s barge,¹⁷ looking into the green, turbid Nile. He has leaned over the still pool of some Greek woodland, and seen in the water’s silent silver the wonder of his own beauty. But he is much more to me than that. I won’t tell you that I am dissatisfied with what I have done of him, or that his beauty is such that art cannot express it. There is nothing that art cannot express, and I know that the work I have done since I met Dorian Gray is good work, is the best work of my life. But in some curious way—I wonder will you understand me?—his personality has suggested to me an entirely new manner in art, an entirely new mode of style. I see things differently, I think of them differently. I can now re-create life in a way that was hidden from me before. ‘A dream of form in days of thought,’—who is it who says that?¹⁸ I forget; but it is what Dorian Gray has been to me. The merely visible presence of this lad,—for he seems to me little more than a lad, though he is really over twenty,—his merely

visible presence,—ah! I wonder can you realize all that that means? Unconsciously he defines for me the lines of a fresh school, a school that is to have in itself all the passion of the romantic spirit, all the perfection of the spirit that is Greek. The harmony of soul and body,—how much that is! We in our madness have separated the two, and have invented a realism that is bestial, an ideality that is void. Harry! Harry! if you only knew what Dorian Gray is to me! You remember that landscape of mine, for which Agnew offered me such a huge price, but which I would not part with? It is one of the best things I have ever done. And why is it so? Because, while I was painting it, Dorian Gray sat beside me.”

“Basil, this is quite wonderful! I must see Dorian Gray.”

Hallward got up from the seat, and walked up and down the garden. After some time he came back. “You don’t understand, Harry,” he said. “Dorian Gray is merely to me a motive in art. He is never more present in my work than when no image of him is there. He is simply a suggestion, as I have said, of a new manner. I see him in the curves of certain lines, in the loveliness and the subtleties of certain colors. That is all.”

“Then why won’t you exhibit his portrait?”

“Because I have put into it all the extraordinary romance¹⁹ of which, of course, I have never dared to speak to him. He knows nothing about it. He will never know anything about it. But the world might guess it; and I will not bare my soul to their shallow, prying eyes. My heart shall never be put under their microscope. There is too much of myself in the thing, Harry,—too much of myself!”

“Poets are not so scrupulous as you are. They know how useful passion is for publication. Nowadays a broken heart will run to many editions.”

“I hate them for it. An artist should create beautiful things, but should put nothing of his own life into them.²⁰ We live in an age when men treat art as if it were meant to be a form of autobiography. We have lost the abstract sense of beauty. If I live, I will show the world what it is; and for that reason the world shall never see my portrait of Dorian Gray.”

"I think you are wrong, Basil, but I won't argue with you. It is only the intellectually lost who ever argue. Tell me, is Dorian Gray very fond of you?"

Hallward considered for a few moments. "He likes me," he answered, after a pause; "I know he likes me. Of course I flatter him dreadfully. I find a strange pleasure in saying things to him that I know I shall be sorry for having said. I give myself away. As a rule, he is charming to me, and we walk home together from the club arm in arm, or sit in the studio and talk of a thousand things. Now and then, however, he is horribly thoughtless, and seems to take a real delight in giving me pain. Then I feel, Harry, that I have given away my whole soul to some one who treats it as if it were a flower to put in his coat, a bit of decoration to charm his vanity, an ornament for a summer's day."

"Days in summer, Basil, are apt to linger. Perhaps you will tire sooner than he will. It is a sad thing to think of, but there is no doubt that Genius lasts longer than Beauty. That accounts for the fact that we all take such pains to over-educate ourselves. In the wild struggle for existence, we want to have something that endures, and so we fill our minds with rubbish and facts, in the silly hope of keeping our place. The thoroughly well informed man,—that is the modern ideal. And the mind of the thoroughly well informed man is a dreadful thing. It is like a bric-a-brac shop, all monsters and dust, and everything priced above its proper value. I think you will tire first, all the same. Some day you will look at Gray, and he will seem to you to be a little out of drawing, or you won't like his tone of color, or something. You will bitterly reproach him in your own heart, and seriously think that he has behaved very badly to you. The next time he calls, you will be perfectly cold and indifferent. It will be a great pity, for it will alter you. The worst of having a romance is that it leaves one so unromantic."

"Harry, don't talk like that. As long as I live, the personality of Dorian Gray will dominate me. You can't feel what I feel. You change too often."

"Ah, my dear Basil, that is exactly why I can feel it. Those who are faithful know only the pleasures of love: it is the faithless who

know love's tragedies." And Lord Henry struck a light on a dainty silver case, and began to smoke a cigarette with a self-conscious and self-satisfied air, as if he had summed up life in a phrase. There was a rustle of chirruping sparrows in the ivy, and the blue cloud-shadows chased themselves across the grass like swallows. How pleasant it was in the garden! And how delightful other people's emotions were!—much more delightful than their ideas, it seemed to him. One's own soul, and the passions of one's friends,—those were the fascinating things in life. He thought with pleasure of the tedious luncheon that he had missed by staying so long with Basil Hallward. Had he gone to his aunt's, he would have been sure to meet Lord Goodbody there, and the whole conversation would have been about the housing of the poor, and the necessity for model lodging-houses. It was charming to have escaped all that! As he thought of his aunt, an idea seemed to strike him. He turned to Hallward, and said, "My dear fellow, I have just remembered."

"Remembered what, Harry?"

"Where I heard the name of Dorian Gray."

"Where was it?" asked Hallward, with a slight frown.

"Don't look so angry, Basil. It was at my aunt's, Lady Agatha's. She told me she had discovered a wonderful young man, who was going to help her in the East End, and that his name was Dorian Gray. I am bound to state that she never told me he was good-looking. Women have no appreciation of good looks. At least, good women have not. She said that he was very earnest, and had a beautiful nature. I at once pictured to myself a creature with spectacles and lank hair, horridly freckled, and tramping about on huge feet. I wish I had known it was your friend."

"I am very glad you didn't, Harry."

"Why?"

"I don't want you to meet him."

"Mr. Dorian Gray is in the studio, sir," said the butler, coming into the garden.

"You must introduce me now," cried Lord Henry, laughing.

Basil Hallward turned to the servant, who stood blinking in the sunlight. "Ask Mr. Gray to wait, Parker: I will be in in a few

moments.” The man bowed, and went up the walk.

Then he looked at Lord Henry. “Dorian Gray is my dearest friend,” he said. “He has a simple and a beautiful nature. Your aunt was quite right in what she said of him. Don’t spoil him for me. Don’t try to influence him. Your influence would be bad. The world is wide, and has many marvellous people in it. Don’t take away from me the one person that makes life absolutely lovely to me, and that gives to my art whatever wonder or charm it possesses. Mind, Harry, I trust you.” He spoke very slowly, and the words seemed wrung out of him almost against his will.

“What nonsense you talk!” said Lord Henry, smiling, and, taking Hallward by the arm, he almost led him into the house.